

My Olympics

P.T. USHA, the queen of Indian tracks, and ace shooter MANSHER SINGH recount how it feels to participate in the biggest sports extravaganza

OF THAT LAST MOMENT DIP

As a 16-year-old, I was the Baby of the Moscow Olympics 1980. Everything about the Moscow Games was bigger than my wildest dreams. It was my first time on an airplane, my first time in an indoor stadium, the first time I saw a synthetic track and the first time I wore my first synthetic track spikes. I was so overawed I could hardly take in what Moscow looked like or

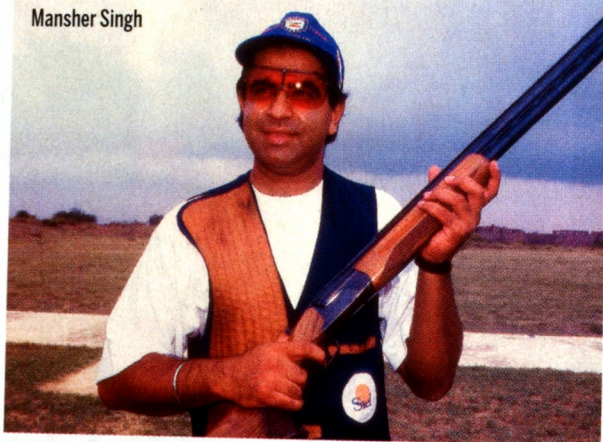
AFP PHOTO



who the other athletes were. On the track, all on my mind was the race. At Los Angeles, I was a different athlete. I was confident of reaching the 400m hurdles final round. We arrived in the US a fortnight before the Olympics and won the 400m hurdles beating the reigning champion Judy Brown at a pre-Games meet at Inglewood. But as destiny would have it, I could not fulfil my greatest dream, missing out on an Olympic medal by one-hundredth of a second. Had I known how to make the crucial 'dip' at the very last instant, I might have been an Olympic medallist. The gold medal that day went to Nawal El Moutawakel of Morocco, who is now a good friend and we are still in touch over e-mail.

as told to **M.G. Radhakrishnan**

Mansher Singh



BHAWAN SINGH

ZERO MARGIN OF ERROR

I first went to the Olympics in 1984 as a schoolboy, and my memories of Los Angeles are still very clear in my mind. I remember the range, I remember how I shot on the day much more vividly than I remember the subsequent Games. When I went back to the Olympics again in 1996 in Atlanta, I was ranked among the top 10 of the world. I had one miserable first day and it was all over. The thing about the Olympics is that you have to shoot high scores. People train really hard and, therefore, get very high performances.

In Athens, you could tell just how much the Games had grown in the last two decades, but what stood out for me the most was the performance of our shooters. It was great to see Chilly Rathore win India's first-ever shooting medal. It did a lot for the sport in India, took it to a whole new level. The aura of the Olympics is such that it keeps you in a spin. The Olympics comes just once in four years—it's your only shot. And you can't afford to be making a mistake.

INDIA'S BOXING CONTINGENT WAS LEFT STRAINING TO VISIT THE COMPETITION VENUE IN BEIJING, THE WORKERS STADIUM, FOR THE LACK OF A BUS.

needs of the Olympic invasion.

The global giants of the English-language media adopt a habitual tone of high dubiousness before every Olympics held in an unfamiliar culture. Not since the Cold War have an Olympics been so politically-charged. Now, despite itself and everything it does, China is ripe for their condescension. Clockwork efficiency can push back the Communist Party, Tibet and Beijing pollution to the

back of the visitor's mind.

The eyes only see a nation on high alert and its combined intent communicates powerfully. In the relentless, round the clock cleaning and polishing, scrubbing and smiling; in security guards at full attention outside doors, at traffic junctions, on the hard shoulders of flyovers, facing fences that face other fences. There are actually two surface to air missiles in readiness near the

stunning Bird's Nest stadium.

Predictably, then the Beijing Olympics are being called a 'clash of civilisations', but these are a globalised Games taking place in what is the world's biggest factory and also its biggest market place. A 'clash', therefore, is as probable as the fencers deciding to duel with chopsticks this fortnight.

All the same, an entire country feels on trial: the US cycling team landed